running hither and thither’.

It has been speculated, not least by contemporary (and competitive) Europeans from other nations, that the Jesuits in the Mughal court were not driven by missionary zeal alone; that they were, in fact, political agents of the Portuguese – if not spies, then certainly charged with helping to safeguard the Portuguese monopoly over trade in the Arabian Sea, which had become, as a modern historian puts it, a ‘Portuguese lake’.[63] Their opinion of Murad, then, would have been keenly observed, especially since the prince, in heading to the Deccan, was also coming dangerously close to Goa. Its Portuguese viceroy would have liked to know if the prince would be a useful ally or a potential threat.

Badauni’s assessment of the prince backs that of the Fathers – that he wasn’t up to much. Murad boasted ‘of being a ripe grape when he was not yet even an unripe grape’, he writes, describing Murad’s behaviour during his first independent charge some years previously.

In 1591, Akbar had sent his middle son to Malwa, with particular instructions to bring the rebellious raja of Orchha, Madhukar, back into the imperial fold. Murad had not wanted to go, it seems, declaring to Akbar that he would rather remain by his father’s side, if only as his ewer-bearer. Besides, he feared he would be slandered by his ‘enemies’ while he was away. Foremost among these foes – if we are to believe one of Badauni’s most unsavoury tales about the imperial family – was none other than Murad’s elder brother, Salim.

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Shortly before sending Murad to Malwa, Akbar had fallen ill and accused Salim of trying to poison him. In 1591, the year after his two falls from his horse and elephant, Akbar was forty-nine years old, and Salim twenty-two. Relations between father and son had been deteriorating, it appears, for a while – not unlikely because the prince had embarked upon his long and spectacular drinking addiction some years ago. (Between the ages of eighteen, when he first tasted wine, and about thirty, when he began to fall ill from it, Salim had progressed to drinking ‘twenty phials of double-distilled spirits, fourteen during the day and the rest at night’.[64] These spirits were no joke. Abul Fazl writes of such ‘*dutasha*’ [twice-burned]